MEMO · FOR A NETWORK-PLANNING TEAM AT AN INDIAN AIRLINE

When one airline fails, passengers stay home

Spare seats and single-airline routes, after December 2025.

October 2026 · Sanjana Maini · full study: sanjanamaini.github.io/indigo

What happened. When IndiGo's crew rostering failed in December 2025, it carried 1.88 million fewer passengers than the season predicted. Other airlines did not carry them: together they flew 0.23 million *fewer* than their own seasonal norm. About 2.11 million passengers simply did not fly.

Why nobody captured them. No airline had seats to sell. The Tata group's December seat-km changed −0.2% from November against a usual +5.7%; Akasa Air's fell slightly against a usual 15%, with planes 95.3% full.

Where it hurt most. On routes where IndiGo was the only airline listed, December traffic fell 15.6 points against trend, against 8.3 on routes IndiGo shared. Those routes stayed about 8.0 points behind through July 2026, and IndiGo ended with a record 67.4% of the market.

Recommendations.

1. **Price a disruption buffer into the peak season.** Wet-leased aircraft or standby crews in December would have met up to two million stranded passengers. Model it as an option: the buffer's cost against the share of a rival's failure it lets you carry.
2. **Screen single-airline routes for entry.** 14.5% of domestic passengers flew routes with no second airline listed. The largest are below, with December growth against each route's own trend (DGCA data, both directions): demand that had nowhere to go.
3. **Verify before acting.** The list comes from public airport listings, not schedules, and current listings show a rival on two of the top three. Re-run it on OAG or Cirium schedule data before any route decision.

INDIGO-ONLY ROUTE, 30 NOV 2025	NOV PASSENGERS	DEC, PTS	SPOT CHECK, OCT 2026
Hyderabad-Kolkata	84,268	−24.0	rival flies today
Chennai-Coimbatore	77,324	−29.7	still IndiGo only
Ahmedabad-Hyderabad	56,598	−29.7	rival flies today
Coimbatore-Hyderabad	48,107	−15.3	not yet checked
Bengaluru-Coimbatore	36,538	−26.7	not yet checked